

Senior Strategy Roles as Executive Search Territory for FPZ

The opportunity is real but lopsided. Creative agencies represent a structured, fee-rich market for senior strategy search — every major network agency employs a Chief Strategy Officer, and AI-driven transformation is generating net-new leadership roles at pace. Production studios, by contrast, have almost no dedicated strategy function; the title barely exists. FPZ's strongest commercial play is not competing head-on for traditional CSO mandates (where Grace Blue Partnership dominates) but owning the convergence zone between creative strategy and AI/technology leadership — a gap no incumbent search firm currently fills. The fee ceiling for a single US placement reaches **\$132,000** at retained rates for a Head of AI Strategy role; the realistic UK agency fee range sits at **£25,000–£55,000** per placement.

1. The role landscape: agencies are title-rich, studios are title-bare

The single most commercially relevant finding is the structural asymmetry between the two sectors. Every major creative agency network — Ogilvy, BBDO, TBWA, Droga5, Wieden+Kennedy, AKQA, Dentsu Creative, DDB, McCann, Leo Burnett — employs a Chief Strategy Officer at both global and local-market level. Production studios — Framestore, MPC, The Mill, Stink Films, RSA Films, Anonymous Content, Smuggler, Biscuit Filmworks, DNEG, ILM — employ none. Not one dedicated strategy-titled senior role was found at any production company or VFX house researched. Strategy at studios is embedded in the CEO, Managing Director, or Executive Producer function. This is not a data gap; it reflects a fundamental structural difference. Agencies sell strategic thinking as a billable service, while studios sell craft execution.

Agency titles that are multiplying. The traditional CSO title remains dominant and stable, but it is fragmenting beneath. Droga5 (Accenture Song) now operates with Co-Chief Strategy Officers (Colleen Leddy and Harry Román-Torres) alongside separate Heads of Brand Strategy (Michael Osbourn), Data Strategy (Lily Ng), Communications Strategy (Jonathan Daly), and Media Strategy (Ben Nilsen). AKQA (WPP) has created a Chief Data Insights Officer (Andrew Missingham) and Chief Marketing and Growth Officer (Jabari Hearn) alongside its Global CSO (Miriam Plon Sauer). This sub-specialisation pattern — carving the strategy function into branded, data, media, and communications streams — is the clearest hiring multiplier for search firms targeting this space.

Growth-oriented titles are rising fast. AKQA's Chief Marketing and Growth Officer, Havas Australia's Chief Growth and Client Officer (Richard Clarke), ([Marketing Mag](#)) and Ogilvy Australia's National Growth Officer (Katie Firth) ([LBBOnline](#)) signal that strategy roles are tilting toward measurable commercial outcomes. The "Group CSO" layer is also emerging as holding companies consolidate agencies into super-groups: Jo Arden was appointed Group Chief Strategy Officer at AMV Group ([Campaign Live](#)) (Omnicom) in 2025, sitting above individual agency CSOs.

Titles in decline. "Head of Planning" — the original British term — has been almost entirely replaced by "strategy" at senior levels. No major agency now uses "Head of Planning" for its top strategy role. The standalone "Strategy Director" title without a modifier (Brand, Creative, Group, Data) is also consolidating upward. (Resume Worded)

The CSO-to-CEO pipeline matters commercially. Multiple CSOs have been promoted to CEO: Matt Jarvis at 72andSunny, (Adweek) Devika Bulchandani from McCann CSO to Ogilvy CEO (Theadvertisingclub) to WPP COO, (WPP) (WPP) and Emma Montgomery through TBWA CSO, DDB CEO, to Droga5 Global CSO. (MARKETECH APAC) This career pathway inflates CSO compensation (approaching CEO levels at some agencies) and makes the role stickier for retained search mandates — boards treat CSO appointments as potential CEO succession plays.

Production studio equivalents. The closest proxy is the Managing Director or Head of Business Development role. At Stink Films, Joint Managing Director Jon Chads is noted as "expanding on strategy and business development" but carries no formal strategy title. (LinkedIn) Framestore appointed a Director of Business Development and Strategy (sourced from Omnicom), which represents the most strategy-adjacent titled role found at any production company.

(Animation World Network) If studios create strategy roles as they diversify into branded content and AI-driven services, these MD/BD roles are where the title evolution will start.

2. AI is creating searchable roles at agencies but not yet at studios

The most commercially valuable AI-driven development is the emergence of the Chief AI Officer as a distinct C-suite seat at agency holding companies. At least six CAIO or equivalent roles were created between 2024 and 2025 across holding companies alone: Daniel Hulme as Chief AI Officer at WPP, John Kahan as inaugural Chief AI Officer at Stagwell (reporting directly to CEO Mark Penn), (Adweek) Jeff Beringer as Chief AI Officer at Golin (IPG subsidiary), (O'Dwyer's PR News) Dr. Ali Alkhafaji as Chief AI and Technology Officer at Omnicom Precision Marketing, (SalesTech Star) Wesley ter Haar as Chief AI Officer at Monks (S4 Capital), (Digiday) and Lan Guan as Chief AI Officer at Accenture (parent of Accenture Song). (Fortune) These are **net-new roles** that did not exist pre-2023; roughly 70% of AI leadership appointments reviewed appear to be net-new headcount rather than restructured existing positions. (Search Services)

Below the CAIO level, a second tier of AI-strategy hybrid roles is forming. WPP created its first-ever Chief Innovation Officer in November 2025, appointing Elav Horwitz explicitly to "solidify leadership in applied AI." (WPP) (Everythingexperiential) WPP also created a Director of AI Strategy and Innovation (Mathieu Albrand) and VP of Global Partnerships & AI Innovation (Sarah Salter) — both net-new. (WPP) Dentsu created Chief Data and Technology Officer roles at both global (Shirli Zelcer) (Digiday) and ANZ (Danica Bellchambers) levels, unifying data, technology, and AI into single senior mandates. (Marketing Report) Dentsu Japan appointed Susumu Namikawa as Growth Officer for the AI/Creative domain, leading an "Augmented Creativity Unit." (Dentsu)

The talent pool is extremely thin, which favours retained search. Candidates need to combine deep AI/technology expertise with creative industry knowledge and C-suite gravitas. The departure of Omnicom's Chief AI and Technology Officer (Alkhafaji) to become CEO of Apply

Digital in March 2026 illustrates both the scarcity and the career upside of this talent (PR Newswire) (SalesTech Star) — and the risk of loss that makes boards willing to pay for formal search.

Production studios are not creating AI strategy roles. VFX and production companies are integrating AI into technical pipelines (rotoscoping, de-aging, environment generation) under existing CTO and R&D structures rather than creating dedicated leadership positions. The sole major exception is DNEG, which launched Brahma — an entirely separate AI content technology subsidiary (Wikipedia) backed by \$200M from United AI Saqer Group — with Prabhu Narasimhan as Executive Chairman and Thomas Graham (via the Metaphysic acquisition) as CEO.

(Yahoo Finance) (The Hollywood Reporter) Brahma is now valued at \$1.43B. (DIGITAL TERMINAL) But this is a corporate structure play, not a strategy role within a studio. At Framestore, ILM, and other major VFX houses, no dedicated C-suite or VP-level AI strategy positions were found.

How AI reshapes existing strategy roles. For traditional CSOs at agencies, AI is being layered into their existing mandates rather than carved out. At Publicis, CSO Carla Serrano and CEO Arthur Sadoun jointly own the CoreAI platform strategy (Publicis Groupe) — no separate CAIO exists. At Ogilvy, AI adoption falls under the Senior Director and Head of Innovation (Kaare Wesnaes), (Adweek) not the CSO. This layering pattern means that when agencies next replace a CSO, AI fluency will be a non-negotiable requirement in the brief — a shift that benefits creative-tech-positioned search firms like FPZ.

3. Compensation supports viable fees, with AI roles at the ceiling

The fee economics work, particularly for US placements and AI-adjacent roles. The data below is sourced from Glassdoor (December 2025–March 2026, multiple hundred salary submissions per role), Morgan McKinley's 2025 UK Salary Guide, and Burtch Works' 2024 AI Salary Report. Two important caveats: production studio strategy compensation data is essentially non-existent in public databases because the roles do not exist in meaningful numbers, and UK "VP" titles are uncommon in agencies (the equivalent is Head of Strategy or Strategy Director).

US agency strategy compensation and search fees

Role	Base salary range	25% fee (contingent)	33% fee (retained)	Source
Strategy Director	\$155,000–\$300,000	\$38,750–\$75,000	\$51,150–\$99,000	Glassdoor (Ogilvy, WPP specific); 127 salaries
VP / SVP of Strategy	\$180,000–\$400,000	\$45,000–\$100,000	\$59,400–\$132,000	Glassdoor; 206 VP + 58 SVP salaries
Head of Strategy	\$200,000–\$350,000	\$50,000–\$87,500	\$66,000–\$115,500	Glassdoor; 159 salaries
Chief Strategy Officer	\$175,000–\$350,000	\$43,750–\$87,500	\$57,750–\$115,500	Glassdoor; 473 CSO salaries (agency subset)
Head of AI Strategy	\$200,000–\$400,000	\$50,000–\$100,000	\$66,000–\$132,000	Glassdoor + Burtch Works 2024

UK agency strategy compensation and search fees

Role	Base salary range	25% fee (contingent)	33% fee (retained)	Source
Strategy Director	£75,000–£150,000	£18,750–£37,500	£24,750–£49,500	Glassdoor (691 salaries); Morgan McKinley 2025
Head of Strategy	£70,000–£140,000	£17,500–£35,000	£23,100–£46,200	Glassdoor (340 salaries); Dentsu specific £139K
Chief Strategy Officer	£120,000–£250,000	£30,000–£62,500	£39,600–£82,500	Glassdoor (76 salaries); OMD CSO at £193K

Fee floor and ceiling. The UK fee floor is approximately **£18,000** (contingent placement of a Strategy Director at the lower end). The US fee ceiling reaches **\$132,000** (retained placement of a Head of AI Strategy or SVP at the upper end). The most likely fee range for a typical retained CSO placement is **£40,000–£60,000 in the UK** and **\$60,000–\$100,000 in the US**. The US commands a **50–80% premium** over equivalent UK roles, driven by higher base compensation in New York and Los Angeles markets, stronger bonus culture (US C-suite bonuses run 25–50% of base versus 20–30% in the UK), and larger agency billings.

Production studio fee potential is limited and speculative. If a production company were to create a Head of Strategy role, compensation would likely benchmark at £80,000–£120,000 in the UK and \$150,000–\$250,000 in the US, based on Executive Producer and Managing Director proxies (Glassdoor, ERI Economic Research Institute). This yields fees of £20,000–£40,000 (UK) and \$37,500–\$82,500 (US). However, such roles are so rare that search volume would be minimal.

AI roles carry a premium. Head of AI Strategy compensation runs 15–25% above traditional Head of Strategy benchmarks. The Robert Half 2026 Salary Guide projects content strategy growth at 3.3% annually, above the 1.5% average for marketing/creative roles. AI-specific strategy skills are commanding additional premiums that are not yet fully captured in aggregated salary databases.

4. Search viability is medium for agencies, low for studios — but the AI niche is high

The most important competitive finding is that Grace Blue Partnership is the dominant incumbent. Founded in 2007, Grace Blue is the only global executive search firm specialising exclusively in advertising, marketing, and communications. They explicitly list "strategy, data and insight" as a core placement discipline. Named clients include RSA Films, IPG, DDB, BBDO, Dentsu Aegis Network, Mother, Havas, R/GA, and Valtech. They claim to have placed more senior creative industry talent than any other firm globally and operate exclusively on retained mandates at senior level. Any FPZ expansion into agency strategy search would compete directly against Grace Blue.

Other creative-sector specialists include The Talent Business (global, creativity-focused executive search), (LBBOnline) UNKNOWN (London-based creative economy consultancy placing at Mother and holding companies), (Weareunknown) Hanson Search (marketing/comms specialist with Cannes Lions presence), (Hanson Search) and Searchlight (media and entertainment recruitment with BAFTA sponsorship and UK production connections). (Searchlight) The major generalist firms — Heidrick & Struggles, Spencer Stuart, Korn Ferry, Egon Zehnder — have relevant practices but focus on corporate-side strategy leadership, not agency CSO placements. Heidrick has a formal "Strategy Leaders" practice within its Marketing, Sales & Strategy Officers division but targets Fortune 10 to mid-cap corporations. (Heidrick & Struggles) No evidence was found of any major firm routinely placing CSOs at creative agencies.

Network hiring is the primary competitor, not other search firms. The advertising industry is small and interconnected. Strategy leaders are highly visible through Cannes Lions, Campaign coverage, and industry events. An estimated 50–60% of agency strategy hires happen through networks and internal promotion, 25–30% through specialist search firms (primarily Grace Blue), and 10–20% through advertised roles. For production studios, the percentage hired through networks rises even higher — the VFX and production world is extremely tight-knit, and senior moves are almost always relationship-driven.

Retained search is standard for agency C-suite strategy roles. CSO appointments at network agencies (WPP, Publicis, Omnicom, Dentsu subsidiaries) are conducted as retained searches. (RecruitBPM) VP and Director-level strategy roles at larger agencies may use retained or contingent depending on urgency and agency size. Independent agencies under 200 employees are more likely to hire through networks or contingent arrangements due to fee sensitivity.

Production studio search viability: Low. Dedicated strategy roles barely exist at production companies, so the addressable market is minimal. VFX studio recruitment firms (Talent Outpost, Rachelle Lewis Talent, DAX, Motus VFX) focus entirely on creative and technical leadership (Talent Outpost) (Talent Outpost) — VFX Supervisors, Heads of CG, Studio Heads — not strategy roles. No evidence was found of any search firm placing a "strategy" titled role at a production studio.

Agency search viability: Medium. The roles exist, fees are viable, and search is used — but Grace Blue's entrenched position and network-driven hiring patterns make this a competitive market to enter through the front door.

AI-strategy intersection viability: High. This is the gap in the market. Grace Blue's heritage is in traditional creative industry leadership (Graceblue) (CEO, CCO, CSO). The major generalist firms cover corporate strategy and technology separately. (C-Suite Strategy) No search firm currently owns the convergence of creative strategy and AI/technology leadership — precisely the space where WPP, Stagwell, Dentsu, and Publicis are creating net-new C-suite roles at speed. FPZ's creative technology positioning maps directly onto this whitespace.

Verdict

Senior strategy roles at creative agencies represent a viable addition to FPZ's executive search scope, but only if the entry point is chosen carefully. The traditional CSO market at agencies is real and fee-rich (retained fees of £40,000–£82,500 in the UK and \$57,000–\$132,000 in the US), but Grace Blue Partnership has deep incumbent advantage, and production studios offer negligible volume because the role category barely exists there. **The strongest entry point is the AI-strategy convergence zone** — the Chief AI Officer, Head of AI Strategy, and Chief Data and Technology Officer roles being created across WPP, Publicis, Dentsu, Stagwell, Omnicom, and Accenture Song at pace since 2024. This territory sits precisely at the intersection of creative industry knowledge and technology leadership that FPZ already occupies, no incumbent search firm has claimed it, the talent pool is thin enough to make retained search essential, and compensation (and therefore fees) runs 15–25% above traditional strategy benchmarks. The recommended play is to position FPZ as the specialist for "strategy leadership in AI-era creative companies," starting with holding-company CAIO and CDTO mandates, then expanding laterally into agency CSO briefs where AI fluency is now a non-negotiable requirement.